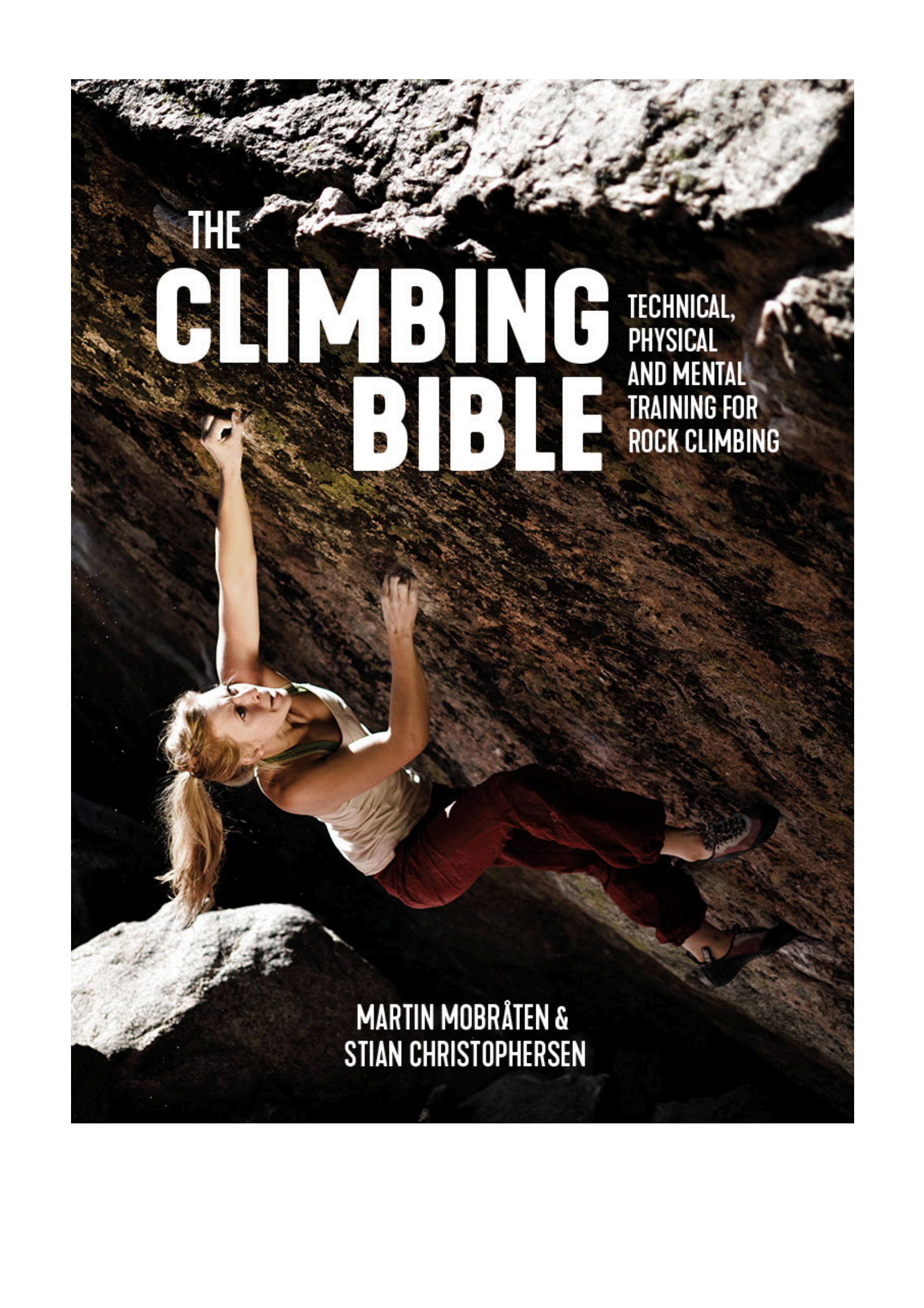


A full-page photograph of a woman with blonde hair in a ponytail, wearing a light-colored tank top and dark red pants, climbing a dark, textured rock face. She is positioned vertically, with her head near the bottom and her feet near the top. Her left arm is extended upwards, reaching for a hold, while her right arm is bent. Her legs are spread apart, with her feet placed on the rock. The background is a dark, craggy rock wall.

THE CLIMBING BIBLE

TECHNICAL,
PHYSICAL
AND MENTAL
TRAINING FOR
ROCK CLIMBING

MARTIN MOBRÅTEN &
STIAN CHRISTOPHERSEN

**THE
CLIMBING
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PHOTO: CHRIS BURKARD

Stian Christophersen enjoys the view from Grande Grotta, Kalymnos, Greece



MARTIN MOBRÅTEN (right) has a master's degree in civil engineering, has climbed for over 20 years, been an athlete on the Norwegian national team and is a former Nordic champion in climbing. He has climbed extensively outdoors and has redpointed several routes graded F8c+ and boulder problems up to Font 8c. Martin has coached the Norwegian Climbing Federation's youth recruits and many of the stronger juniors in the Trondheim community for the past ten years. Martin works daily with climbing courses, route setting and facilitating climbing both indoors and outdoors.

STIAN CHRISTOPHERSEN is a physiotherapist and coach, has climbed for over 20 years, been an athlete on the national team and was the 2009 Norwegian bouldering champion. He has also climbed extensively outdoors and has first ascents of routes up to F8c and boulder problems up to Font 8b+. Stian is a former national team coach in climbing and is a personal trainer for several of Norway's best climbers. He has also been responsible for the Norwegian Climbing Federation's education of coaches, and in addition to running his own physiotherapy practice he educates the next generation of coaches at both a national and international level.

THE CLIMBING BIBLE

MARTIN MOBRÅTEN & STIAN CHRISTOPHERSEN

Translated by Bjørn Sætнан

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MARTIN

Mum and Dad, thank you for allowing me to follow my passion!

Maria, it's just awesome that I get to share climbing and the rest of my life with you!

STIAN

Thank you, Dad, for all the amazing trips and for introducing me to what has shaped my life. Thank you, Karianne, for your patience and for always helping me when I'm stuck. Thank you, Mum, for always believing in me, no matter what.

Kasper and Oda, this one's for you.

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PHOTO : DAG HAGEN

‘I REALISED, AS A FORTY-YEAR-OLD, I HAD REDISCOVERED THE FUN OF OUR CHILDHOOD GAMES. AND NOT JUST ANY GAME, BUT INDEED A GAME THAT IS MUCH MORE REAL THAN WHAT THEY CLAIM REALITY ITSELF IS.’

THE GAME

FOREWORD BY JO NESBØ

When I was young, we used to play cowboys and Indians. I was the youngest but gained respect from the older kids because of my ability to die spectacularly. I wasn't afraid to fall off branches slightly too high up the tree if I felt the need to add a certain panache for visual effect. On our way home after our battles, we passed civilians carting their baby strollers, washing their cars, mowing their lawns and performing other peaceful, meaningless and tedious tasks. And I thought: Damn it, do these people really not realise that mere metres away a war has been fought on matters of life and death?

Thirty-five years later I found myself clinging to a climbing wall, high up on the famous Thaiwand Wall at Railay in Thailand. As I looked down, 80 metres straight into the sea, I realised that if I theatrically grasped my chest, let loose my Indian-howl and fell, this time it would not only be a spectacular fall, but also a very real death. Unless of course this preposterously thin strand of rope would serve its purpose and catch me, which my future climbing buddy told me it always does, usually. I died three or four times that trip, yet always managed to claw my way back to life, fuelled by a cocktail of adrenaline, survival instinct, physical strength I didn't possess, and mental stamina previously unknown to me. Furious cursing and uninhibited roars of delight, fear and laughter, both eyes blind and sudden revelations, imminent success turned sudden panic, plans of retreat and white flags turned into a resolute struggle against limestone, demons and gravity. And on our way back from the jungle, while passing by a luxury beach speckled with tourists gleaming of sunscreen, I thought: Damn it, do these people really not realise that mere metres away a war has been fought on matters of life and death?

I realised, as a forty-year-old, I had rediscovered the fun of our childhood games. And not just any game, but indeed a game that is much more real than what they claim reality itself is.

Because climbing is of course exactly that, fun and games. We do not need to master climbing steep walls. There is no food to be found there, and hence other forms of exercise like running, swimming, riding a horse or going skiing are much more likely to bring food to the table the day the power grid shuts down. Climbing is as close to the premise of child's play as you can get – 'Hey, let's see who's able to climb up there!' And as I continued to pursue climbing, it was with a certain level of bewilderment I realised that despite the fact that it's pure fun and games, many are willing to sacrifice time, sweat and tears to become good climbers. Or at least better. Myself included. But I also realised that very few of those who were putting in the effort were basing their training on anything other than what they had picked up from other climbers, experiences from other sports and personal ideas and experiences with what seemed to provide progress with their climbing. In a time where the science of training in even the tiniest of sports has been professionalised, scrutinised and analysed – why not also climbing? As an outsider coming to climbing from other sports, it was with wonderment I came to realise that systematic training was frowned upon by a large portion of the climbing community. Perhaps related to the somewhat unclear standards of climbing – the 'real' connection with nature versus the competitive ideals of the industrial society, the natural talent versus targeted routines. But the fact is that even though the goal of these childish games is to have fun, getting better at the game is also part of the game. And I think now there is a trend towards perceiving training not just as a part of, but as an extension of the game. Most of us – we who shall not go down in climbing history – can find deep satisfaction in setting personal goals and achieving them with the means we have at our disposal, be it technical talent, strength, attitude and mentality, playfulness, discipline or sheer power of will. This is why a book addressing improving one's technique, training methods, strategy and injury prevention is welcome as an extension of this game of ours, as a tool in the challenge to see 'who's able to climb up there!'

As I'm writing this, I have just completed the hike down from Kolsåstoppen, near Oslo, after battling loose holds, basalt, and rhomb-porphry, and have met smiling passers-by greeting me with: 'Having fun in the sun, are we?' And I have smiled back and thought: They know nothing.

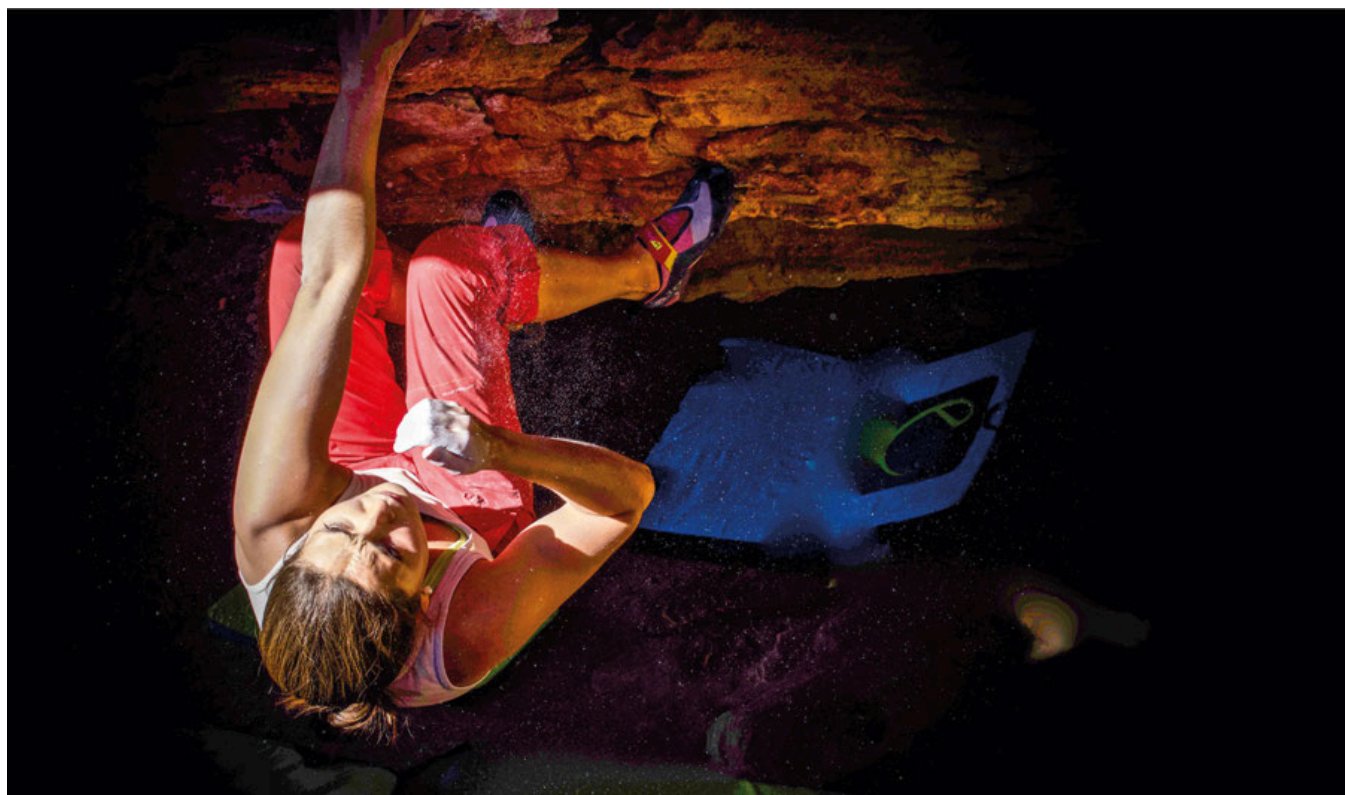


PHOTO: BJØRN SÆTNAN

Maria Davies Sandbu on Un Petit Hueco Dans Rocklands (Font 7b+), Rocklands, South Africa.

THE REASON WE write this book is twofold. Firstly, the interest in climbing has never been greater. While climbing as an outdoor activity used to be characterised as alternative and even a bit weird, the sport of climbing has now become commonplace. More and more people are seeking climbing as a fun and challenging activity and form of exercise, both indoors and outdoors. Secondly, after over two decades of climbing as a passion and job, we wanted to gather and present in writing our documented and experience-based knowledge to provide the tools and inspiration needed for both new and more experienced climbers to take their own climbing to new heights.

This book highlights technical, physical and mental performance factors and how these can be trained so you can raise your climbing level. Further topics are tactics, how to plan your training and injury prevention measures. Our goal is to provide you with practical tools to raise your level and to help children, adolescents and adults stay injury free and enjoy as much of this wonderful sport as we have over the last 20 years.



HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

This book is built around the three classic performance factors in climbing: technical, physical and mental. In the technique chapter, we cover various foundations for all movements on the wall and more specific techniques, before we conclude with tips on how to train these on your own. The physical training chapter focuses on specific strength, endurance and mobility training for climbing; a separate chapter is devoted to general strength and injury prevention, in which we present basic principles on how you can reduce the risk of injury, and a brief overview of common climbing-related injuries. The chapter on mental training deals with mental characteristics that are central to climbing performance and how these can be trained. The book also looks at tactics and training planning and is seasoned with shorter topics such as friction, skincare and tales about good training environments and people or stories which have inspired us.

The chapters are structured so that the most basic information comes first, before moving into more in-depth topics towards the ends of the chapters. For example, the descriptions of various techniques starts with the most basic and ends with the most advanced – which you are unlikely to need until you are climbing at a relatively high level.



At the very back of the book you'll find a list of words and expressions we climbers like to use, both at the crag and when writing books like this.

Movements in climbing are varied in the sense that no two movements are ever quite the same. It is important to build a large repertoire of movements when you start climbing. We therefore recommend that less experienced climbers focus on the chapters on technique and mental training. Various techniques are presented here; when they fit and how they can be trained. Advanced climbers will find that all chapters have relevant parts, because climbing is a complex sport and it is important not to specialise too much in one area if you want to improve. Nevertheless, you should become aware of your own strengths and weaknesses and prioritise your training focus based on the area in which you want to perform. There is a big difference between training for indoor bouldering competitions and preparing for long, pumpy outdoor sport routes. By reading this book we hope to help you with this process by giving you the tools, motivation and some inspiration on your way to new heights.

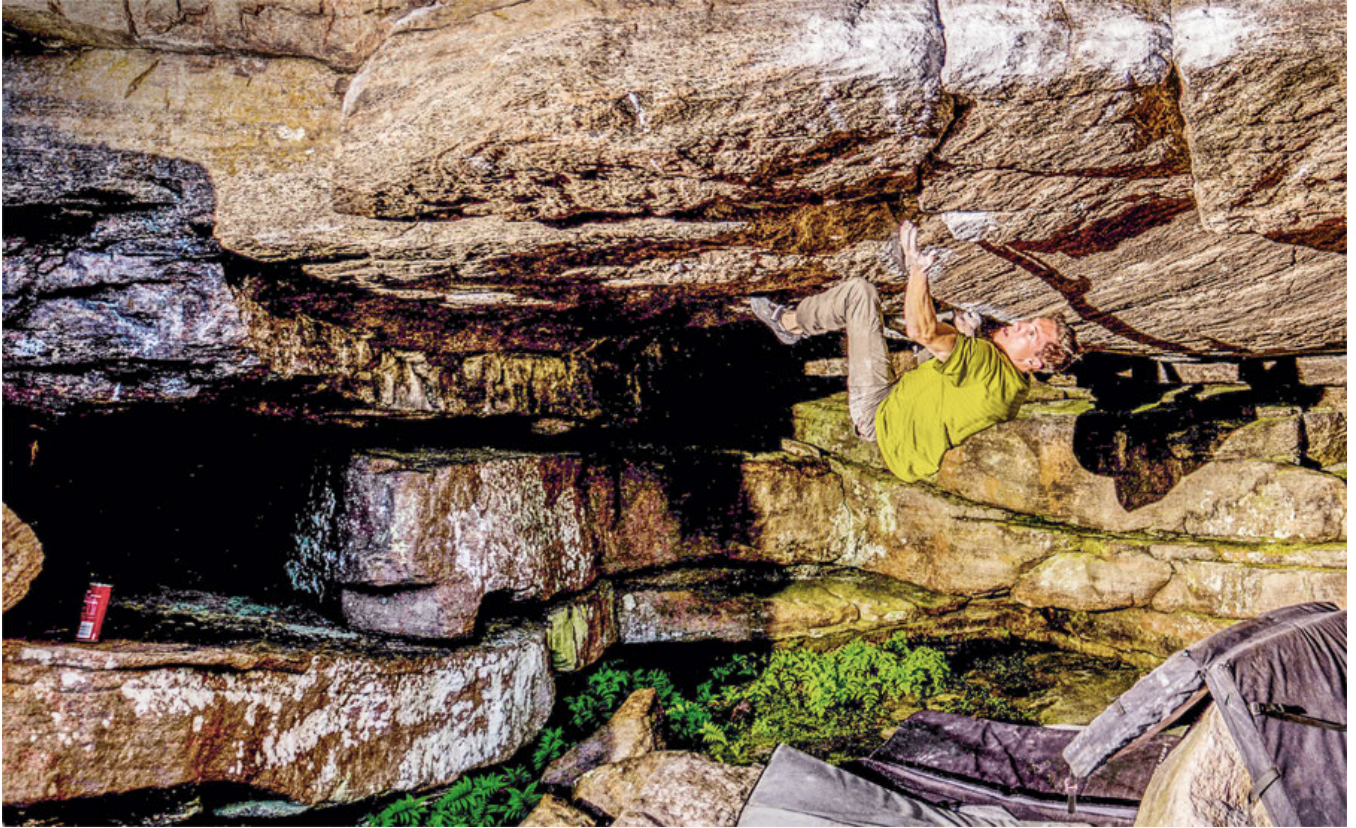


PHOTO: BJØRN HELGE RØNNING

Stian Christophersen on Trøbbel (Font 8a+), Harbak, Norway.

WHAT CAN HISTORY TEACH US?

Climbing today is a combination of play and training, with and without a rope, performed both indoors and outdoors. It is our clear belief that all aspects of climbing are important for maintaining motivation over time and improvement. The communities and generations that have fostered strong climbers here in Norway – because it is often a certain community or generation that has distinguished itself – have often been those who have embraced the various multitudes of climbing. They have alternated between running hard workouts and competition-like bouldering indoors, and have gone on both short and long bouldering and sport climbing trips to play on real rock both at home and abroad. They have done these activities together and helped raise each other to the next level in the process. Because if you think about it, it's hard to become a great climber on your own. Someone has to spot you and belay you, and discussing beta with a friend is a huge advantage. Your community will also push you during training and make sure you have fun when on your climbing travels.

PLAY AND TRAINING

As Jo writes in his foreword, in many ways climbing is divided between the two slightly contradictory elements of play and training. Play is perhaps the element which best characterises climbing when compared to more traditional forms of exercise like running or weightlifting. Picture your average bouldering session: you're sitting on the mat, chatting about this and that, discussing moves, and every now and then you try a boulder. You roll across the mat after failing on a dyno move while your friends are laughing. For most of us this closely resembles the play of our childhood memories. On the other hand, we typically associate training for climbing with fingerboarding, pumped forearms and stretching. You might decide to do a route five times in a row to build endurance for the project you're working on. This is tiresome and painful, and most people would not consider this playing.

Many climbers prefer playing and try really hard to avoid what they consider training, while other climbers love to train and forget to play all together. Because you are reading this book you probably have the intention to improve as a climber. To achieve this you must train, but you should also not forget to play. Playing is just as important in order to improve as a climber as it is to crimp on the fingerboard or repeat routes until you're pumped. It's typically when you're playing that you learn new intricacies of technical movements, and playing will keep climbing from becoming boring and monotonous like other forms of training might be. At the same time, by training specifically on technical, mental and physical factors, you'll be more consciously aware of how you're moving on the wall, and increase both your physical and mental fitness. Combining targeted training and play will make you a better climber, and they should not be seen as contradicting elements, but instead as symbiotic building blocks.

And remember, even the more traditional forms of training can be made to feel more like play. Many of the best athletes credit their performance to having fun all the time, even when training. So play and have fun every time you train!



PHOTO: BJØRNAR SMESTAD

ABOUT TRAINING PHILOSOPHY

In many countries there has been quite a physical focus on training philosophy for many years. In countries such as Japan, a focus on playing with movements is stronger, and there is less focus on the physical. We might be going out on a limb here, but we believe that some climbers have placed too much emphasis on physical training and this is reflected in their climbing – we often see climbers with poor technique. From our own time as competition climbers in Norway, we were told that we had to distinguish between training and climbing. This is a logical distinction, but it is important to emphasise that one should not exclude the other. You can distinguish between sessions where the focus is more on play and sessions where you train specifically, but do not focus on one at the expense of the other.

